MARYLEBONE ROSTER · DECEMBER 2026 LINK · THE SHORTLIST

Four good links, one edge each

Second Edition, Short Run, Even Keel and Closing Time, against each other and against today's link

What all four share

Thirteen designs are in the pack; these four balance best what weighs most here. Everything below holds for all four, each line better than or level with today; what they share that is worse than today is on page 2.

✓ All **9 of 9** December staffing rules (today 4), and the flexible ones bar one: Closing Time's brief moved its closer from 15:45 to 16:00

✓ **7 full weekends off in 26**, never more than 5 weeks apart (today 4 in 20, up to 7 apart)

✓ Every closing shift **shorter, by 30 minutes to 1h 15m** — Sunday's 8h 10m on all four (today 8h 55m); no shift over 9h 00m

✓ **No avoidable fatigue warning**, and never more than 6 days in a row even with a cover week placed badly (today 5 warnings, up to 9 days)

✓ The same **35-hour** week and **218.6 days** a year, under the ceiling of 219 (today 219.0)

✓ **4 single rest days**, as today; rest days otherwise in pairs or longer (22 of 26 breaks, today 13 of 17)

Where they differ

the best of the four on each line in bold green; today for scale, not ranked

MEASURE	TODAY	SECOND EDITION	SHORT RUN	EVEN KEEL	CLOSING TIME
Most days in a row, fixed rota	7	6	**5**	**5**	**5**
Heaviest week	43h 50m	42h 00m	42h 30m	**41h 30m**	**41h 30m**
Lightest week	25h 10m	25h 30m	24h 30m	24h 30m	**27h 00m**
Shortest rest between shifts	12h 30m	14h 20m	14h 20m	**14h 35m**	**14h 35m**
Closing shift, weekday	8h 40m	8h 10m	8h 10m	8h 10m	**7h 55m**
Closing shift, Saturday	9h 10m	8h 40m	8h 40m	8h 40m	**7h 55m**
Weeks on one turn (one shift time Mon–Fri, no mixing)	7 of 16	**18 of 21**	**18 of 21**	**18 of 21**	17 of 21
Weeks mixing earlies and lates	7	**0**	**0**	1	**0**
Longest block of earlies or lates (up to: with cover weeks)	2 (up to 3)	**5 (up to 7)**	**5 (up to 7)**	5 (up to 12)	**5 (up to 7)**
Week-to-week change of start time	4h 00m	**1h 01m**	1h 13m	1h 16m	1h 10m
Finishing at 23:00 or later, each a year	39	**42**	**42**	44	**42**
Finishing at 22:00 or later, each a year	78	**94**	**94**	**94**	104
Shift times to learn that are new	0 of 18	6 of 15	6 of 15	7 of 15	**5 of 13**
Fit to the trains, weekday · Sat (0 = exact; Sunday 29.0 on all four, today 71.7)	52.0 · 65.9	**29.1** · 12.7	**29.1** · 12.7	29.4 · 14.5	36.4 · **8.7**

Each one's edge

Second Edition SE-26-F1 · dea6417f

The steadiest. One shift time Monday to Friday in 18 of 21 weeks and the gentlest week-to-week change of the four, 1h 01m. Its cost is the one the other three have shed: six days in a row on the fixed rota.

Short Run SR-26-F1 · 618348d6

Second Edition without the sixth day. The same duty table — the closest fit to the weekday trains, 18 weeks on one turn — with no run over 5 days on the fixed rota, for one 42h 30m week (Second Edition 42h 00m) and a 1h 13m step.

Even Keel EK-26-H1 · 8e9a1bcf

A fourth person to the Saturday close. Its own duty table: no week over 41h 30m and at least 14h 35m between shifts, as on Closing Time — for 44 late finishes a year (the others 42), 7 new times, 1 mixed week and a block of lates up to 12 weeks.

Closing Time CT-26-T2 · 77a235bc

The shortest closers. Today's link on 26 lines: every closer Monday to Saturday starts at 16:00, 7h 55m (the others 8h 10m, and 8h 40m on a Saturday); today's 13:45 stays; weeks run 27h 00m to 41h 30m. It pays with 104 finishes a year at 22:00 or later (the others 94) and 17 weeks on one turn (the others 18).

Which one, by what matters most

IF THE MAIN PRIORITY IS	CHOOSE
Five-day runs, the most weeks on one turn, and the fewest late finishes	**Short Run**
The shortest closing shifts, and the fewest new shift times to learn	**Closing Time**
A fourth person to the Saturday close	**Even Keel**
The steadiest start times from week to week	**Second Edition**
Four weeks off for 14 days' leave, as today	**Long Break** · outside the shortlist

THE SHORTLIST · CONTINUED

Against today, and a recommendation

On most of what a colleague feels the four are the same — a figure in grey is shared by all four

Against today's link

MEASURE	TODAY	SECOND EDITION	SHORT RUN	EVEN KEEL	CLOSING TIME
Full weekends off, in the rotation	4 in 20	7 in 26	7 in 26	7 in 26	7 in 26
Full weekends off, about a year	10	14	14	14	14
Longest wait between full weekends	7 weeks	5 weeks	5 weeks	5 weeks	5 weeks
Contracted days at work a year	219.0	218.6	218.6	218.6	218.6
Saturdays a year, each	26	28	28	28	28
Sunday overtime duties a year, each	21	20	20	20	20
Starting at 06:20, each a year	62	60	60	60	58
Average shift, Monday to Saturday	8h 14m	8h 16m	8h 16m	8h 16m	8h 16m
Longest shift	9h 10m	9h 00m	9h 00m	9h 00m	9h 00m
14 days' leave buys, at best	30 days off	28 days off	28 days off	28 days off	28 days off
14 days' leave buys, at worst	19 days off	20 days off	20 days off	20 days off	20 days off
Leave for four full weeks off	14 days	15 days	15 days	15 days	15 days

Per year: the rotation's count scaled to 52 weeks. Days a year are Monday to Saturday, a cover week counting four.

Why these four and not the other nine

These four balance best what weighs most here — days in a row, weekends, one shift time a week, late finishes. Most others keep something none of the four has, at a price: Long Break four weeks off for 14 days' leave and a 29-day best stretch, for a fifth single rest day, 16 weeks on one turn and a 1h 44m step; Home Grown 12 shift times, only 2 of them new, and Both Ways today's 13:35 and 13:45 every weekday, a 40h 55m heaviest week and only 4 new times, each for a weaker fit to the trains (Sunday most), 16 weeks on one turn and a rougher step; and Second Look, Second Nature, Second Sight and Second Wind blocks of earlies or lates a week shorter, for six days in a row on the fixed rota and fewer weeks on one turn. Fine Tune and Second Gear keep nothing the four lack.

The honest costs, shared by all four

- **Late finishes.** 42 a year each at 23:00 or later (today 39), 44 on Even Keel; 94 at 22:00 or later (today 78), 104 on Closing Time. Three to the close every day, where today's weekdays have two, means no link meeting the rules has fewer than 42 at 23:00 or later.
- **Leave.** The best 14-day stretch is 28 days off, not today's 30; four full weeks off, Sunday to Saturday, takes 15 days' leave, not 14. The worst stretch is a day better. All four are worse than today here, on something people plan a year around; Long Break alone keeps the 14.
- **Saturdays.** About 2 more a year each (28, today 26) — fourteen on a Saturday, the flexible rule, shared across 26 lines (today ten across 20).
- **New times.** 6 of 15 shift times are new on Second Edition and Short Run (9 are worked today), 7 of 15 on Even Keel and 5 of 13 on Closing Time. Several of the new ones are shorter versions of today's lates: every closer starts later, and the Sunday office late finishes earlier.

Recommendation

> **Short Run.** It is Second Edition's duty table laid without the six-day stretch: 6 days in a row on Second Edition's fixed rota, never more than 5 on Short Run's (six for all four if a cover week falls badly), for 30 minutes on the heaviest week and 12 minutes on the week-to-week step. Against Closing Time, with the same five-day runs and weekends, it keeps one more week on one shift time, the closer fit to the weekday trains (29.1 against 36.4) and 10 fewer finishes a year at 22:00 or later; Closing Time's closers are shorter, by 15 minutes on a weekday and 45 minutes on a Saturday, and its weeks more even. It weighs a sixth day in a row most, then late finishes and one shift time a week; a colleague who weighs the closing shift most may reasonably prefer Closing Time, and steady start times, Second Edition.

But the choice is closer than the tables make it look. On the app's weighted league the four finish within a point and a half of each other out of a hundred, Closing Time and Second Edition level at the top. So choose by the edge that matters here:

- **Choose Short Run** if days in a row and late finishes are what colleagues raise first.
- **Choose Closing Time** if the closing shift matters most: a 16:00 closer Monday to Saturday, today's 13:45 kept, the fewest new times and the most even weeks — for 10 more finishes a year at 22:00 or later.
- **Choose Even Keel** if a fourth person to the Saturday close matters more than two late finishes a year and a seventh new time. Like Closing Time it is on its own duty table — a genuine alternative, not a variant.
- **Choose Second Edition** if steady shift times week to week carry the day: the gentlest change of the four and a lighter heaviest week than Short Run, at the price of the six-day stretch.